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BOOK TWO

SILENCE came over them all; eyes focused upon him intently.

Father Aeneas arose on his deep-pillowed couch and began thus:*

'Words can't express, my queen, what you bid me relive, all the rueful

Pain: telling how the Danaäns destroyed Troy's wealth and its power

5 Makes for a dirge of lament. Heartbreaking events. And I saw them,

I was a major part of them all. What Myrmidon soldier,

Or what Dolopian, what man who served under callous Ulysses

Could find words, yet hold back tears? And, besides, night is shedding

Dew from the sky, and stars as they fade persuade us to slumber.

10 'Still, if you're so much enamoured with learning how ruin befell me,

Also with hearing, though briefly, of Troy's last afflictions, its death-throes,

Though my soul, still shocked by the memory, recoils from the anguish,*

Let me begin.

'The Danaän command, now shattered by warfare,

Beaten aside by the fates, seeing years slither on into more years,

15 Crafted a horse, thanks to Pallas' divine skill, high as a mountain,

Built on a framework of ribbing with interlocked sections of pitch pine.

"Vowed to ensure our return!" was the lie passed onwards by rumour.

Inside its flanks, unseeing, unseen, they secretly sealed up

Bodies of men they'd selected—for lots had been drawn. And they loaded

20 Deep in its vast hollow spaces, its womb, quite an army of soldiers.

'From Troy's shores you can make out an island called Tenedos, famous,

While Priam's empire endured, for its wealth of resources, now merely

Coasts with a bay that affords unreliable mooring for vessels.

That's where the other Greeks sailed. And they hid on its desolate coastline.

25 We, though, concluded they'd now shipped out on the winds for Mycenae.

So all Teucra too cast off long moorings to anguish.

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Gates were flung open. What pleasure it was to go into the Greek camp,
 See the deserted sites and the beaches abandoned and empty!
 Here's where Dolopians tautened their tents; there, savage Achilles.
 30 Here's where the fleets once lay; over there occurred most of the fighting.
 Some just gawked at the ruinous gift from the virgin Minerva,
 marvelled at its sheer mass. Thymoetes was first to encourage
 Bringing the horse inside our walls to a place in the castle:
 Treachery maybe; perhaps Troy's fate already in motion.
 35 Capys, however, and others whose minds proved sounder in judgement,
 Thought it a ruse the Danaäns had planned, a suspicious donation,
 Argued for pushing it into the sea, lighting bonfires beneath it,
 Or drilling into, and probing, its womb's hollow caves of concealment.
 Popular sentiment wavered and split into two opposed factions.
 40 'Enter Laocoön first—and a large crowd of followers with him—
 Running, ahead of the rest, from the citadel, blazing with passion,
 Shouting while still far off: "Poor citizens, what utter madness
 Seizes you? Do you believe the foe's gone, or that gifts from Danaän
 Donors don't involve ruses? Is that what we know of Ulysses?
 45 Either this structure of wood is concealing Achaeans inside it,
 Or it's an engine of war they've designed to destroy our defences,
 Spy on our homes, make aerial assault on our city, or some less
 Evident trap. Sons of Teucer, whatever this horse is, be careful.
 I am afraid of Danaäns, not least when they offer donations."
 50 This said, he launched at its flank, with enormous force, a huge javelin
 Into the wild beast's paunch, at a curve in the joints of its structure,
 And hit his mark. For it stuck there and quivered. The cavernous hollows
 Rang with the sound of the wounded womb and emitted a deep moan.
 Had not god-given fates, divine minds (and our own) been against us,
 55 That would have driven our swords to turn Argive lair into bloodbath,
 Troy would endure to this today; you'd still stand, fortress of Priam.

'Meanwhile, observe, some Dardanian shepherds are dragging a young man,
 Hands tied behind him, straight to the king, with a great deal of shouting.

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They didn't know him. The youth had approached them himself to surrender
 60 Willingly, and with a purpose: to open up Troy to Achaeans.
 Trusting his own courage, he was prepared for both possible outcomes:
 Either he'd pull off his treacherous ruse or he'd die, that was certain.
 Eager to view him, the young men of Troy surged up, spilled around him,
 Each one vying to outdo the others in taunting the captive.

65 Mark how Danaäns set traps. From this one criminal instance
 You'll learn them all.*
 Well, as he stood before everyone's gaze, roughed up and defenceless,
 As he surveyed with his eyes all the Phrygian forces around him,
 "Oh," he said, "what land on earth, what oceans can ever accept me?
 70 More to the point, what hope of survival remains in my grim plight?
 I've no possible place with Danaäns; Dardanians also
 Hate me, as one of the foe. They demand retribution and bloodshed."
 Attitudes changed as he groaned, thus suppressing all urge to attack him.
 Rather, we begged him declare where he came from and tell us his bloodline,
 75 Say what he wanted, explain why he'd trust us and risk being captured.
 'Finally, setting his terrors aside, he addressed us as follows:
 "Truth, sir, whatever the cost," he began, "I'll admit to you frankly,
 All of it. I won't deny I'm an Argive by birth. That's the first truth.
 See, none* of Fortune's twists that have bent Sinon low as a beggar
 80 Will also craftily bend him so low as a fraud and a liar.
 Possibly you've heard the name of a man that they call Palamedes,
 Belus' descendant.* His glory, once rumour, is now a tradition.
 Well, the Pelasgians tried him on trumped-up charges of treason—
 Since he was always opposing the war. Though he never was guilty,
 85 They planted evidence, put him to death. Now they're sorry they killed him.
 He was, by blood, close kin of my own; so my penniless father
 Sent me here to the wars in his company during those first years.
 While his status as king stayed safe—and in our kingly counsels
 Weight was accorded his words—I enjoyed some importance and standing.
 90 When he departed the shores of this life, thanks to guileful Ulysses'
 Envious eye—and I'm not saying things that you don't know already—
 I was crushed too; and I trudged through life in the dark grip of anguish,

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Fiercely resenting the fall of my friend, who was guiltless, as I was.
 Mindlessly, I didn't keep my mouth closed: I vowed I'd avenge him,
 95 If chance arose, if we won, if I ever got home to my native
 Argos. In speaking these words, I set vicious hatred in motion.
 This was when I commenced my own slide to disaster. Ulysses
 Kept me, from now on, in terror with endless new accusations,
 Spread ambiguous talk in the ranks, plotted, hunted for allies.
 100 Nor did he rest till the day when, with Calchas'* priestly assistance ...
 Why am I wasting time unscrolling a tale of no interest?
 Why delay now? You have heard quite enough, if you catalogue *all* Greeks
 Under one heading: I'm Greek. So get on with it, carry out sentence.

That's what Ulysses would want. The Atreidae would amply reward you."
 105 This left us burning to delve even deeper and find out the reasons.
 We didn't know the full scope of Pelasgian criminal cunning.
 'Feigning fear, he resumed, and, with crafted sincerity, added:
 "Often Danaäns yearned to quit Troy and effect a withdrawal,
 Get themselves out of a lengthy war that had left them exhausted.
 110 How I wish they had gone! Often violent storms on the seaways
 Cut off escape. When they sailed, southwesterlies beached them in terror.
 That day was special. The horse built with planking of interlocked maple*
 Stood complete. But the whole vast sky was rumbling with storm clouds.
 Baffled, we sent Eurypylus* off to find answers at Phoebus'
 115 Oracle. But his report from the shrine was completely horrendous:
 'Blood was your means of placating the winds—for you slaughtered a virgin
 When you were first on your way, you Danaäns, to Ilium's coastline.
 Blood is the price, if you want to go home, and the sacrifice human:*\br/>
 Argive, again.' When the sound of his voice reached their ears, every soldier's
 120 Heart stopped, stunned. Through their bones' very marrow ran shivers of icy
 Fear as to whom fate readied to strike, who was sought by Apollo.
 Major uproar ensued when Ulysses dragged the seer Calchas
 Into our midst at this moment, demanding that he explain clearly

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What the gods willed. Many now were predicting that this cruel schemer's
 125 Target of crime would be me, but stayed quiet and watched what developed.
 Calchas withdrew into silence for ten days, wouldn't surrender
 Anyone by any word he might say and condemn him to slaughter.
 Forced, only just, to agree, by the Ithacan's loud protestations,
 He, at last, burst into speech; marked me to be killed on the altar.
 130 Everyone shouted approval. All energy feeding each person's
 Fears for himself was refocused on one poor wretch, to destroy him.
 ' "Now that indescribable day was approaching. The detailed
 Rites for my death were in hand: salted meal, ribboned bands for my temples.
 Well, I admit it, I broke my restraints, I escaped my appointed
 135 Death. I hid all night unseen in the sedge of a mud-filled
 Swamp. I was waiting for them to set sail, if by some chance they *did* sail.
 There's no hope that I'll ever again see *my* former homeland,
 My dear sons or my father—and oh, how much I have missed him!
 There's a good chance that the Greeks will penalize *them* because *I* fled,
 140 Make *them* pay, poor things, full price for *my* sin with *their* lives.
 So, by the powers above, such forces as know what the truth is,
 By any trust, any pledge, that remains unbroken by mortals

Anywhere now, I implore you! Oh, pity my terrible sufferings,
Pity a soul who's enduring a lot undeserved and unworthy!"

- 145 'Tears won him life, which we granted. We freely gave him our pity.
Priam himself took the lead, giving orders to strike off his shackles
And the connecting chains, then addressed him in tones full of friendship:
"Henceforth, whoever you are, forget you have lost Greece for ever.
You will be ours. Now tell me the truth as I ask you this question:
150 Why did they build this enormous hulk of a horse? Who designed it?
What's the idea? Some rite of religion? Some engine of warfare?"
This said, he, well-schooled in ruse and Pelasgian cunning,
Raised up his hands, all chains now shed, palms high to the heavens.
"O eternal fires, whose will lies beyond violation,
155 O unholy altars and steel-edged blades I've evaded,
O ribbons, sacred to god, that I wore as a victim, bear witness!

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Justice absolves me of oaths, which Greeks hold solemn and sacred,
Justice demands that I hate these men, that I bring all their secrets
Out in the open. I'm bound by none of the laws of my homeland.

- 160 All I ask—if you're saved—is that *you* honour *your* vows and pledges,
Troy, if I tell you the truth and I pay back your kindness with interest.
' "Every Danaän hope and assurance in war, once it started,
Always relied upon Pallas's help. This fact was the reason
Tydeus' unrighteous son* and that expert in outrage, Ulysses,
165 Came for and stole that fatal talisman, Pallas's image,
Out of its holy shrine, and butchered the citadel's sentries.
They stole the sacred Palladium away, desecrating her ribboned
Temples, divinity's vital and virginal symbols, with bloodstained
Hands. After this, the Danaäns' hopes turned to water beneath them,
170 Seeping away. Strength snapped. The goddess's mind remained hostile.
There was no doubting the signs the Tritonian gave: they were monstrous.
Hardly was her image placed in the camp when its eyes began bulging,
Flared wide, leaping with flames. Salt sweat oozed over its body.
Three times the goddess herself, like a flash (it's a marvel to mention),
175 Leaped from the ground as she brandished her shield and her spear—and they
quivered.
' "Out of the templed sky* it flashed upon Calchas that they must
Make an attempt to sail home, since Argive steel couldn't uproot
Pergamum till they'd retaken the omens at Argos, and brought back
Numinous powers they had plundered away in the holds of their vessels.
180 That's why they've now gone heading off home on the winds for Mycenae.

Arms and the gods are prepared—reinforcements as well. Then they'll recross
Seaways and catch you off guard. So Calchas interprets the omens.

' "Warned to make up for profaning the image and power of Pallas,
Greeks, to atone for their ugly injustice, created this creature.

185 Calchas required that a statue be built of enormous proportions,
Stretched up high as the sky in a structure of interlocked planking:
That meant it couldn't be brought past the gates, dragged into the city,
Shielding its folk through traditional bonding of gods with their dwellings.

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Yet, if some Trojan hand violated this gift to Minerva,

190 Wholesale disaster would fall upon Phrygians, upon Priam's empire—
Heaven forbid! May the gods turn back this curse upon Calchas!—
Were it, said Calchas, to enter your city, if *your* hands should drag it,
Asia would triumph and march on the fortifications of Pelops:
Such would be fate's doom in store for our people's descendants."

195 'So spoke Sinon, an artist in perjury, setting his ambush.
And we believed him. He fooled us with well-staged weeping and ruses,
Conquering men neither Tydeus' son nor Larissa's Achilles,
Not even war's ten years and its thousand vessels could vanquish.

'Then, something greater was cast in our hapless way, something far more

200 Frightful. It startled and muddled our minds. We could not have foreseen it.
Neptune's priest, Laocoön, chosen by lot for this honour,
Stood sacrificing a victim, a monstrous bull, at the altars.
Look! Across tranquil depths, out of Tenedos, writhing and coiling,
Big orbs swishing a course, twin serpents—I shudder, recalling—
205 Slither the sea's face, stretch for the shore in their parallel lunges.
Now, amid surf, chests standing erect, crests mane-like, in aspect
Blood-red, up they surge on the swell, bodies skimming the water,
Spiralling measureless tails in whiplash whirls of propulsion.

Foaming brine crashes noise. In a trice they have reached the enclosure.
Flickering, viperous tongues lick mouths spitting sibilant hisses,

210 Eyes blaze, reddened with fire and with blood in a sanguine suffusion.
Anguished and pale at the sight, we scatter; they form into columns,
Seeking Laocoön. First, each serpent entwines his two children's
Tiny bodies in coils of embrace and, poor little fellows,

215 Feasts upon limbs that its jaws just crunch and ingest at a single
Gulp. When he seizes his weapons and runs up to help them, the serpents
Pluck him away and constrict him in monstrous spirals; already
Two coils squeeze the man's waist; and their scaly backs, interlacing,

Noose two more round his throat. Their necks, their heads, tower above him.
220 Struggling to push them away with his hands, and to rip their garrotting

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Knots from his throat, he's awash in their poisonous blood-blackened venom.
Constant, appalling screams he shrills and shrills to the starry
Sky, like the bellowing pain of the bull who's escaped from his altar
Maimed, and who's shaken the badly aimed axe from his neck where it struck him.
225 Meanwhile the dragon pair slithers up to the high temple summit,
Fleeing for refuge within the ferocious Tritonian's fortress,
Finding protection beneath the goddess's feet and her shield's orb.
'New terror sneaks into every heart, each already pulsing
Wild in its fear; and Laocoön, men begin saying, has simply
230 Paid for his crime, as he surely deserved, since he had, with his blade-point,
Pierced holy wood, stabbed the horse in the back with a murderous spear-cast.
Soon there's a general demand that this symbol be brought to the temple
And that the goddess's grace be implored.
We start to breach our own walls, we open our city's defences.
235 Everyone joins in the work: setting rollers under the creature's
Feet, to facilitate sliding, and hawsers of hemp, to get traction,
Over the neck. Thus war's fatal engine, pregnant with soldiers,
Scales our walls. Young boys all round her and unmarried maidens
Hymn her with songs, take delight in the touch and the tug of her hang ropes.
240 She follows, meek in her menace, and glides to the heart of our city.
Ilium, fatherland, home of my gods, so famous in warfare,
City of Dardanus' sons! Four times she gets stuck and she falters
Not at our gate but upon the gate's slabstone. And four times the weapons
Clang in her womb. We press on, though, blind in our madness, oblivious,
245 Placing this monstrous fulfilment of doom in our citadel's sanctum.
Even now Cassandra discloses our doom, but, as always,
God's divine orders ensure that we Teucrians fail to believe her.
We, poor fools, decorated our deities' shrines in the city,
Wreathed them with boughs for a feast on the day Troy died, as the gods willed.

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250 'Hours and the sky roll on. Night falls, spreading out from remotest
Ocean, enshrouding, in dankness and dark, both earth and the heavens—
Myrmidon treachery, too. Draped over the ramparts, the Teucrians
Slump into silence, limbs hugged tight by the sleep of exhaustion.
Argive infantry, now like marines in a naval formation,
255 Put out from Tenedos, tacitly, lovingly, lanterned by moonlight,

Heading for beaches they know. On a signal of fire from the flagship,
 Sinon, protected by fate and iniquitous gods, slips the pinewood
 Bolts from their slots, as a burglar does, and releases Danaäns
 Locked in the equine womb. Once opened, the horse starts restoring
 260 Soldiers to fresh air. They spring from the hardwood caverns delighted:
 Captain Thersander and Sthenelus too, and ruthless Ulysses,
 Shimmying down a suspended rope; there was Acamas, Thoas,
 Peleus' grandson too, Neoptolemus; first was Machaon,*
 Then Menelaus and then this ruse's designer: Epeus.
 265 In they march, on a city embalmed in a wine-sodden slumber.
 Sentries are slaughtered, and every gate unbolted and opened.
 Now they can let in the troops, join ranks with their allies in purpose.

'This was the time when sleep's first wave sweeps over our mortal
 Frailty, and gods' most agreeable gift slithers into our beings.
 270 There in my dreams, right in front of my eyes, I seemed to see Hector
 Nearby, deeply depressed, flooding tears in a copious torrent,
 Blackened with gore-clotted dust, as he was that day when the chariot
 Dragged him by straps threading gashes slashed in his still swelling insteps.
 Oh, how he looked! How changed, alas, from the Hector I'd once seen
 275 Clad in Achilles' arms sloughed off in defeat by Patroclus,
 Or when he torched the Danaän ships with his Phrygian firebrands!
 Filth now covered his beard and his clumped hair, matted and blood-caked;
 Now he wore only the numerous wounds he'd received round his homeland's
 Walls. I saw myself, through my tears, make the first move, addressing
 280 Hector, in tones of despair, and expressing these thoughts to the hero:
 "O Dardania's light, most reliable hope of the Teucrians,

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What has delayed you so long? Oh, Hector, what land have you come from?
 How we've been waiting for you! And to see you like this! We're exhausted—
 Many you know are now dead, we've endured every kind of affliction,
 285 Human and civic. What act of dishonour has savaged your features
 Once so calm and sublime? Or why else am I seeing you wounded?"*
 Wasting no time, not a word of response, on my vacuous questions,
 He just groaned a deep groan from the innermost depths of his being:
 "Oh," he said, "flee now, child of the goddess, get out of this firestorm.
 290 Foemen have taken the walls. Troy has fallen, from peak into chasm.
 Priam and homeland are finished. If Pergamum could be defended
 My right hand would already have done the defending in *my* time.
 Troy is entrusting to you its icons, its guardian spirits.

Take them as fate's fellow travellers, find great walls to protect them,
295 Walls you will build when your sea-borne wanderings reach their conclusion."

This said, he thrust in my hands the ribbons and image of potent
Vesta and brought her eternal flame from her innermost sanctum.

'Anguish in all of its forms, meanwhile, echoes all through the city,
Louder and louder, its chaos of screams. Though my father Anchises'
300 House was so well tucked away, a retreat overarched by its tall trees,
Sounds start to sharpen, the ghastly rasping of weapons advances.
Shaking off sleep, I climb to the highest point of the rooftop,
Stand there, listening for sounds, my ears pricked up and attentive.
Think of a wildfire's sweep through wheatfields, powered by the roaring
305 Southerlies. Think of a flash flood exploding through banks of a mountain
Cataract, flattening fields, ripe crops, all the hard work of oxen,
Ripping whole forests away. Add a shepherd high on a rock ridge
Far above, hearing he doesn't know what kind of sound in his stupor.

'Then truth dawns on the eye. We begin to see how the Danaäns
310 Trapped us. Deiphobus' opulent home has imploded, erupting
Vulcan's flames to the sky and his neighbour Ucalegon's mansion
Blazes. The straits of Sigeum are now a vast mirror of fire.
Clamour of warriors rises and blends with the clangour of trumpets;
Mindlessly, I seize arms, without thinking too clearly what purpose

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315 Arms should serve. Grab a fistful of comrades and rush to the fortress,
Fight! That's the fire in my soul. Wrath and fury have jettisoned reason.
Taking its place is a slogan: that death, under arms, has its beauty.

'Up comes Panthus,* who's just now eluded Achaean bombardments,
Panthus, Othrys's son, who was priest of the fortress and Phoebus,
320 Running with arms full of relics and vanquished gods, dragging one small
Grandson, and scurrying up to my house, mind lost in his panic.
"Where's the real heart of the fight? What point should we take as our stronghold,
Panthus?" I'd hardly spoken these words when he said with a deep groan:
"Doomsday has come, inescapable hour of Dardania's destruction.

325 Trojans we were. But no more. No more Ilium, no more stupendous
Glory for Teucer's sons. Savage Jupiter's moved it to Argos,
All of it. Now, in our blazing city Danaäns are masters.
Standing tall in the centre of town, that horse is disgorging
Armoured hordes. Sinon, gleeful in victory, mocks us and scatters
330 Fire. Of the thousands who ever arrived from the mighty Mycenae,
Some keep watch at our great double gates, others cordon off narrow
Alleyways, spears levelled, ready for action. A battle formation

Solid with steel is unsheathed, blades honed to a glittering sharpness,
 Poised for the kill. Even those on our front lines, the guards at the gateways,
 335 Mount hardly any resistance; they're fighting a foe that they can't see."
 'Stung by the words of Othrys's son and by promptings from heaven,
 Off I'm whirled into flames, into combat wherever Erinys,
 War's grim demon, and uproar and sky-pulsing clamour direct me.
 Rhipeus joins me and Epytus too, a remarkable fighter,
 340 Allies emerging in moonlight, then Dymas and Hypanis also,
 Gather around at my side, and, with them, the youthful Coroebus,*
 Mygdon's son, who was, so it chanced, at Troy during those days.
 Mad, burning love for Cassandra had forced him to come there, as would-be
 Son-in-law, bringing his aid and support to the Phrygians and Priam.

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345 He went unfulfilled, not heeding advice that his pledged bride
 Uttered in clairvoyant frenzy.
 'I, when I saw these warriors united and burning for battle,
 Offered these words: "Young men, you bravest of hearts in a hopeless
 Cause, if your clear desire is to follow a leader who boldly
 350 Challenges death, this is it. You see how our fortunes are faring:
 All of the gods, on whose strength this empire stood, have forsaken
 Altars and shrines. They're all gone. You are running to save an already
 Burned city. So, let's die, let's rush to the thick of the fighting.
 There's just one way to live with defeat: Don't hope to outlive it!"
 355 'Youthful courage is thus augmented by rage. We are henceforth
 Predators roving the mist-veiled dark, wolves driven by raging
 Bellies and blindly forced from our lairs, where cubs we've abandoned
 Wait dry-jawed. We stride through the volleys of arrows, through foemen,
 On to a death beyond doubt in a resolute march to the city's
 360 Centre as dark night circles her caverns of shadow about us.
 Who could translate into words that night's disaster and killings?
 Who could shed tears that express those oceans of pain that engulfed us?
 That day an old city died after so many years of dominion.
 Everywhere bodies were strewn in her streets, in her houses, her sacred
 365 Shrines dedicated to gods, bodies numberless, motionless, lifeless.
 Teucrians weren't alone in their shedding of blood in atonement.
 Even in conquered hearts, now and then, courage found resurrection.
 Swords struck conquering Danaäns as well. Everywhere there was cruel
 Anguish, everywhere terror—and death in its manifold guises.
 370 'Our first Danaän, Androgeos, heading a large squad of soldiers,

Thought, for he didn't know better, that we were an allied contingent.
So, he came up and addressed us with friendly, spontaneous banter:
"Hurry up, lads! You're late! What's holding you back? Are you idle
Slackers? The others have torched all Pergamum, and they're enjoying
375 Plunder and rape. Have you only just now come ashore from the tall ships?"

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Then he divined in a flash—for our less than convincing responses
Roused his suspicions—that we, those he'd just fallen in with, were foemen.
Dumbstruck, suppressing his stride and his voice, he began to edge backwards,
Just as one suddenly backs off in terror, while sweating through rugged
380 Bush, if one's foot presses down on an unnoticed viper that rears up
Angrily, puffing its dark-hooded neck. So Androgeos faltered,
Trembling at what he'd just seen, and began to retreat in the same way.
We rushed in and engulfed them in one massed onslaught of weapons.
Trapped as they were by their shock, in an unfamiliar location,
385 We simply killed them at will. Thus Fortune smiled on our first deed.
'Arrogant in our success, and emboldened at this point, Coroebus
Said: "Let us follow, my comrades, the route towards safety that Fortune's
First stroke points to, a way where she shows herself ready to help us:
Let's switch shields with them, let's put on this Danaän equipment.
390 Ruses or bravery, who cares which when you're dealing with foemen?
They'll be our armourers!" This said, he donned Androgeos' helmet,
Crested with plumes, then he strapped on his shield, quite superbly emblazoned,
Fitted an Argive sword at his hip, readjusting the buckle.
Rhipeus did just the same, so did Dymas and all of the young men,
395 Joyfully, each one arming himself* with the fresh fruit of plunder.
'Marching, but under this borrowed protection, we mixed with Danaäns.*
In the indifferent blindness of night, we provoked and engaged in
Battles galore, sent Danaäns galore to the dark pit of Orcus.
Some scatter back to the ships, racing off for the shorelines they *can* trust.
400 One group, shameless in fear, climbs back once more up the ladders
Into the monstrous horse, nestles deep in the womb they remember.

'No one may justly trust in the gods when the gods won't be trusted.
Here, alas, was Cassandra, the virgin daughter of Priam,
Dragged by her unribboned hair from Minerva's temple and sanctum,

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405 Vainly extending the blazing light of her eyes toward heaven,
Only her eyes; for chains locked her delicate palms in their bondage.

This sight taxed to its limits the frenzied mind of Coroebus
Who, determined to die, now hurled himself at her captors.
All of us followed in tight formation and charged at the column.

- 410 'Now's the first time we are crushed by our own side's volleys of missiles
Launched from the shrine's high roof. It's the start of a pitiful slaughter
Caused by the misjudged look of our arms, by our helmets with Greek crests.
Then the Danaäns attack, drawn in from all sides by the angry
Crying and groans as the virgin's abducted: the hotheaded Ajax,
415 Atreus' pair of sons too, and the whole Dolopian army.
Much as colliding fronts in a storm will produce a tornado:
Westerlies crash into south winds and easterlies, loving to joyride
Horses of sunrise. Woodlands are howling and Nereus, frothing with fury,
Whips up the sea from its bottommost depths with the swish of his trident.
420 Even the troops that we once, in disguise, under cover of night-time,
Chased through the shadows, dispersed in their panic all over the city,
Now reappear. They are first to detect that our shields and our weapons
Lie about who we are, and to note that our language is different.
Sheer numbers now overwhelm us in seconds. Our first loss, Coroebus,
425 Falls to Peneleus' hand at the altar of armoured Minerva.
Rhipeus is next. He was Troy's most just individual of all time,
Ultimate champion of fairness. He dies—for the gods took a different
View of him. Dymas and Hypanis perished, the victims of friendly
Volleys and, Panthus, your utterly righteous life and Apollo's
430 Ribbons of priesthood gave *you* no protection when *you* began stumbling.
Ashes of Ilium, flames that destroyed my people for ever,
Witness my oath: as you fell, I had no wish to live by avoiding
Any Danaän devices or weapons. Had *my* death been fated,
My deeds done would have earned it.

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pg 42

- 'But we were just torn from the action,
435 Instantly called, by the uproar and shouts, to the palace of Priam,
Iphitus, Pelias, and I. Just three; and old age was impeding
Iphitus. Pelias, too, had been slowed by a wound from Ulysses.*
'Here we saw raging a battle so large that it was as if conflict
Couldn't occur elsewhere, as if no other people were dying
440 All through the city: a total war with Danaäns assaulting
Rooftops, attacking beleaguered portals in tortoise formation:*
Ladders clamp against walls, men fight on the rungs for a footing
Straight below gateposts. Left hands thrust out shields against arrows,
Ward off spear-casts, right hands grasp at the parapet's crenels.

445 Dardans respond, tear turrets apart, strip down entire rooftops.
These, as they stare death full in the face and can see it's their last stand,
These are the weapons deployed in defence as they hunt for projectiles,
Toppling gilded rafters, the height and the glory of ancient
Heritage, down on the foe. Others form into close ranks, blockading
450 Lower approaches and guarding them, swords drawn, ready for action.
'Courage arose in us now to run up to the king's palace, bringing
Vital relief to its veteran defence, new verve to the vanquished.

'Hidden from sight was a doorway, the access point to connecting
Tunnels within Priam's palace: a postern ignored by attackers.
455 Through it Andromache, unfulfilled even while the realm lasted,
Frequently walked to her in-laws' suite with her son, unescorted,
Dragging* Astyanax up to his grandfather's rooms for a visit.
Entering here, I climbed to the top of the roof's highest apex
From which the Teucrians pelted a hand-launched, useless bombardment.
460 Over the roof, itself high to the heavens, a tower had been raised up,
Standing above a precipitous drop. One would go there to look out
All over Troy, at Danaän ships and Achaean encampments.
Prising with steel all around, where the upper structural courses
Showed signs of slippage, we tore it away from its seating support beams,
465 Then pushed hard. First it slid, then it suddenly crumpled,
Burst, with a roar, into showers of debris that spread over Danaän
Forces. But others moved up. There was no intermission in volleys
Either of rocks or of all other kinds of projectile.

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pg 43

'Right at the palace's gate and directly in front of the courtyard
470 Pyrrhus dances* in glittering bronze, ecstatic in swordplay,
Much like a viper emerging to light from his frigidly frost-clad
Den below ground, all swollen from feeding on poisonous grasses.
Now, though, he's sloughed the old skin, he's reborn to youth's colourful brilliance,
Coiling his slippery back, he lifts breast and head high to the sunlight,
475 Darts forked tongue from his mouth, flashes brightly in flickering menace.
'With him, huge Periphas stands, and his squire, who'd once driven Achilles'
Horses, Automedon. They, joined by all the young fighters from Scyros,
Launch an attack on the palace, pitch firebrands onto the rooftops.
Pyrrhus, up front, double axe in his hand, tries breaching the massive
480 Gateway and tearing the bronze-clad doors from their hinges and mountings.
Cutting a cross-beam loose, he smashes the solid oak inward,
Opening up a great window* revealing a wide panorama:

Views of the palace within are disclosed, long stretches of courtyard;
Views of the innermost chambers of Priam and kings of the old days.
485 Now they see bodyguards standing at arms right there at the entrance.
 'Screaming chaos reigns in the heart of the palace. The hollow
Hallways howl with the keening of women's laments and the rhythmic
Beating of breasts: vast sound drums glistening stars in its uproar.
Terrified mothers roam aimlessly through huge chambers, embracing,
490 Clinging to, fixing their kisses upon their defenders: the doorposts.
 'Pyrrhus, true heir to his father's violence, persists. Neither locked bolts
Nor armed guards can withstand him. He's using a ram now, and batters
Furiously. Doors yield, ripped from their mounts, crashing down to inertia.
Force surges forward. Danaäns burst in through the entrance and slaughter
495 Front-line defenders, then fill the whole breadth of the courtyard with soldiers,
Wilder than foaming floodwaters bursting escape through the levees,

.....
pg 44

Sweeping all structures set in their way with their violent torrents,
Racing in rage through the ploughlands, dragging both cattle and cowsheds
Over the plains in a single mass. I saw with my own eyes
500 Pyrrhus, frenzied with killing, and Atreus' twins at the entrance.
Hecuba, her hundred daughters, I saw them, and, sprawled on an altar,
Priam, his own blood polluting the holy fires he had kindled.
Fifty bedrooms he had, grand hopes for a new generation,
Doorways gilt with barbarian gold, decorated with plunder,
505 All lying desolate. Where fires fail, the Danaäns take over.

'Maybe you'd like to hear Priam's fate* recounted in detail.
Once he had seen Troy's capture and fall and the breach of his palace
Gates and the enemy right in the heart of his own private quarters,
He, though long out of practice and elderly, pulled on his armour,
510 Vainly—his shoulders were palsied with age—buckled on his now useless
Sword and set off on his own to meet death where the foe gathered densely.
Centrally placed in the palace, completely exposed to the heavens,
Stood a huge altar, adjacent to which was a very old laurel,
Leaning across it, enfolding the household gods in its shadow.
515 Hecuba, also her daughters, were crowded in vain at this altar
Where, like doves, they had swooped to escape the dark tempest approaching,
And were now sitting, embracing the various deities' statues.
When she saw Priam himself rigged out in the arms of his young days,*
"My dear pitiful husband," she said, "what ghastly decision
520 Prompted your arming yourself like this? And where are you rushing?

This kind of help, and defenders like you, are not what the crisis
Needs. My own Hector, were he with us now, wouldn't make any difference.
Come here instead, lord. For either this altar will give you protection
Or you will die with the rest!" When she'd said this she drew him towards her,

525 Seating this ancient man in a holy sanctuary's refuge.

'Look, one of Priam's sons, named Polites, has just escaped Pyrrhus'
Murderous hand. He has fled through the spears, past the foeman

pg 45

Down through long colonnades and is crossing the now empty courtyard
Wounded. But hot on his heels, and intent on inflicting the death-blow

530 Pyrrhus pursues, and he's now within arm's reach, he's thrusting his javelin.

Lurching in front of the faces and eyes of his parents, Polites
Finally crumples and spews out life in a fountain of dark blood.

Priam, at this point, though already trapped in a circle of killing,
Can't hold back. For he doesn't suppress all his wrath, he proclaims it.

535 "You will pay dear for this crime," he declares, "you will pay for this outrage.

If any power in heaven feels righteous concern in such matters,
May gods show you the thanks you deserve, pay you back in the proper
Coinage for staging my son's death here, and for making me watch it,
You have disfigured a father's face with the blood of his son's death.

540 You are no child of Achilles, you liar. He never mistreated

Priam, his foe, like this! He blushed for shame, he respected
Rights that are granted a suppliant, he showed good faith by returning
Hector's blood-drained corpse* for interment, and me to my kingdom."
Once he'd spoken, the elderly man made a feeble strike with a powerless

545 Spear. And it fell, with a clang, on the bronze shield, instantly halted,
Then dangled limply down from the top of its central embossment.

Pyrrhus replied: "You'll report this, then, to my father Achilles,
Fully, in person. Remember to tell him the tale of my grisly
Actions. Describe Neoptolemus just as he is: a degenerate bastard.

550 Now: die."

'While he was speaking, he pounced on the quivering Priam,
Dragged the king, slipping in pools of his own son's blood, to the altar,
Grabbed his hair, yanked back his head with his left, with his right drew his
gleaming

Sword which he then buried up to the hilt in the flank of the old king.
So ended Priam's role, as prescribed by the fates. His allotted

555 Exit made him a spectator at Troy's Fires,* Pergamum's Ruin,

This man once in command of so many countries and peoples,
Ruler of Asia! He's now a huge trunk lying dead on the seashore,

Head torn away from his shoulders, a thing without name, a cadaver.

pg 46

'Then, for the first time, brutal horror beset me on all sides.

- 560 Rooted me down stock-still. Stealing into my mind came my cherished
Father's face as I watched that king, just his age, being butchered,
Gasping his life out. Then in stole the thought of Creusa, deserted,
Thoughts of my home being plundered, the fate of my little Iulus.
Glancing around, I assess what forces I have to support me.
- 565 All have deserted, exhausted. They've either just hurled their own weakened
Bodies down to the ground or consigned them to death in the fires.
- 'I was the last one alive* when I saw her on guard there at Vesta's
Shrine,* keeping silent and well out of sight, in its innermost sanctum:
Helen, Tyndareus' daughter.* The flames, as I wandered at random,
- 570 Passing my eyes over everything, shed the light needed to see her.
She, common demon of war for both Troy and her homeland, foreseeing
Teucrian wrath because Pergamum fell, then Danaän reprisals,
Then the rough ire of the husband she'd left, had now hidden in terror,
Crouched by the fires of the altar, unseen by their eyes full of hatred.
- 575 Flames were now rife in my soul, ire rose up within me, demanding
Vengeance for my dying homeland and summary, criminal justice.
"Must she see Sparta again unharmed—and her uncle's* Mycenae—
Riding in glory, a queen who has just given birth to a triumph?
Is she to see married life, her ancestral home and her children,
- 580 Served by a court full of women from Troy and of Phrygian pageboys,
Though Priam died by the sword, though Troy is but one massive bonfire,
Though our Dardanian shore has sweated out blood beyond measure?
No! While you don't win a glorious name if you punish a woman,
Here is a victory earning its own special kind of approval.
- 585 I will be praised for destroying the blight of a curse, for exacting
Punishment earned, and my soul will be glad it has duly accomplished
Vengeance we burned for*—and sated the thirsting ash of my nation."
Such were my rioting thoughts as my mind's rage swept me towards her.

'Then, so presenting herself to my eyes that I had to observe her,

- 590 Clearer than ever before, and illumining night with her brilliant

pg 47

Radiance, my gracious mother shone forth in that nature and stature
Usually visible solely to gods. She, proclaiming her godhood
Thus, took my right hand in hers and restrained me. Her rosy lips added:

"Son, what monstrous pain spurs such uncontrollable anger?
 595 Why do you rage? Where's your care for me, and your family, vanished?
 Why not look first where you've stranded Anchises? He's old and he's tired,
 And he's your father. See whether Creusa, your wife, is still living,
 What of Ascanius, your boy? Greek forces are everywhere, wandering
 Round them, encircling them all, and if I didn't love and protect them,
 600 Flames would be snatching them now, foe's swords would be draining their
 lifeblood.
 Blame doesn't lie with the evil-eyed face of Tyndareus' destested
 Spartan bitch, or with Paris. It's gods' inclemency,* gods' will,
 Ruining all this wealth, dashing Troy from its heights into rubble.
 Look, I will tear back the whole of the veil now shrouding your vision,
 605 Clouding death-doomed eyes into dullness with blurring and misty,
 Darkness. But you mustn't now be afraid of your parent's instructions.
 And don't refuse to obey these commands whose force is apparent.

' "Here, where you see massive bastions wrecked, blocks torn from supporting
 Blocks, where smoke intermingled with dust sweeps upwards in billows,
 610 Neptune is shaking foundations and toppling walls with his mighty
 Trident. He's prising the whole city up and away from its bedrock.
 Juno, most brutal of all, is the first in control of the Scaean
 Gates over here, with a sword at her side, in a frenzy, and calling
 Allied troops from the fleet.
 615 There, look, Tritonian Pallas, who's taken the citadel's summit,
 Sits in a cloud flashing lightning, ferocious with aegis and gorgon.*
 Jupiter boosts courage, heightens success for Danaäns, in person,
 And himself rallies the gods into war on Dardanian forces.
 Son, get out quickly, escape. Put an end to this effort you're making.
 620 I'll be on hand the whole time and I'll get you home safe to your father's."
 This said, she merged herself back among ghostly shadows of night-time.
 And, in her place, there appeared the appalling faces and mighty

pg 48

Forces divine that detested Troy.
 That's when my eyes really saw all Ilium slowly subsiding
 625 Into the fires, saw Neptune's Troy prised up from its deep-set
 Roots, like an ancient ash on a mountain's peak when the farmers
 Cut her and hack her with steel, with relentless blows of their axes,
 Vying to fell her for sport. She's been threatening to crash, she's been yawing,
 Tresses of foliage shivered, her head in incessant convulsion,
 630 Slowly succumbing to gashes and rips before rumbling her final

Death crackle, torn from her ridge, sprawled prone in destructive destruction.

'On my descent, I set out between foeman and flame with the goddess
Guiding me.* Weapons withdraw from my path, flames back off before me.
Yet, when I actually made it through to the gate of my family's

- 635 Home and ancestral estate, my father, the first one I looked for,
First one I wanted to carry away to the heights of the mountain,
Flatly refused to extend his own life, now Troy was cut from it,
And face the rigours of exile. "It's you," he said, "you with the solid
Strength of physique and as yet of an age when you're fit and full-blooded,
640 You who must make your escape!
Me? Had the gods in their heavens willed *me* to extend my own lifespan,
They'd have preserved me my homeland. I've already seen Troy
Fall once.* That's much more than enough; I've lived through its capture.
Think of me now as a corpse laid out, say farewell and get going!
645 I'll figure out how to die. Some foeman will show me his mercy,
He'll have his thoughts on the spoils. Dispensing with burial's easy.
Gods' evil eye has been on me. For years I've been helpless and useless,
Just killing time since that moment the father of gods and men's ruler
Blasted me down* with his lightning and scarred me with burns from its fire."
650 Voicing such memories, he stood fast, immovably stubborn.
We—that's Creusa, my wife, and Ascanius, in fact, the whole household—
Argue, with torrents of tears, that he shouldn't, as head of the family,
Wilfully wreck it along with himself, and increase our oppressive

pg 49

Fate. He refuses and sticks to his plan, sits tight in the same spot.

- 655 'Total despair gets me back under arms. I now want, I now choose death.
What other course did fortune allow? What choice was I granted?
"Father, did you think or hope I could run off and leave you abandoned?
Did such a monstrously unjust thought find voice in my father's
Mouth? If the gods want to leave not a trace of a once mighty city,
660 And, if it's settled, resolved, to add both you and yours to the doomed Troy's
Ruin, your doorway to death's wide open. For Pyrrhus is coming,
Fresh from the bloody disposal of Priam, beheading the ruler's
Son right in front of his father; the father on top of an altar.
Mother divine, did you snatch me away through the fighting and fires
665 Just so I'd see the foe here in the innermost rooms of my own home,
Watch as Ascanius dies, see my father, along with Creusa,
Slaughtered like beasts, each one all awash in the blood of another?
Arms, men, stand to your arms! Life's last day summons the vanquished!

Throw me upon the Danaäns again, let me go back and restart
 670 Combat. Never shall all of us die this day without vengeance."
 'Buckling a sword on again,* I was sliding my arm into shield-straps,
 Making them taut, and preparing to leave my house for a second
 Time. But my wife blocks the door, won't budge, grabs hold of my ankles,
 Keeps pushing little Iulus directly in front of his father.
 675 "If you're just leaving to die, rush us off to face everything with you.
 Taking up arms* means to lay down a wager on winning. You know this!
 Yet you abandon your little Iulus, your father, and me too—
 Once called your partner in marriage— to who knows what. Guard your home first!"
 'Such were her cries. She was filling the house with her echoing sorrows
 680 When there arose a most sudden, remarkably wonderful portent.
 During the conflict of looks, words, arms between desperate parents,

pg 50

Look, a slim halo of light seems to shine from the crown of Iulus'
 Head. And it's shedding a glow that can touch without burning: a gentle
 Flame licking over his tresses and grazing the down on his temples.
 685 Scared by the sight into spasms of fear, we flail the ignited
 Hair and extinguish the sacred flames with our fountains of water.
 Father Anchises, however, eyes raised to the stars in elation,
 Stretched out his palms, reached out with his voice to the heights of the heavens:
 "Mightiest Jupiter, if your resolve ever bends when petitioned,
 690 Look at us, that's all I ask. If our righteousness shows we deserve it,
 Then, Father, show us an augural sign* that this was a true omen."
 'Hardly were these words said by our family elder, when thunder
 Suddenly crackled away to our left and a star shot from heaven,
 Trailing a flare most intensely bright as it dashed through the darkness.
 695 Over our rooftops it sped in its fall. And we watched as its brilliance
 Then disappeared in the mountain forests of Ida, defining
 Where we must go. And the pathway its long trajectory furrowed
 Glowed light; all of the area round us was smoky with sulphur.
 That's when my father admitted defeat. For he raised himself upwards,
 700 Made his address to the gods, offered prayers to their sacrosanct comet.
 "No more delay for us now. I am here. Where you lead, there I follow!
 Gods of my homeland, look after this house, and look after my grandson.
 This is your augural sign. Troy now has its being in your will.
 Yes, son, I yield. I no longer refuse to leave here as your comrade."
 705 That's all he said.
 'Now we heard, spreading all through the city, much clearer
 Sounds of the fire. Hot winds roll billowing flames ever closer.

"Come, my dear father, let's leave! Set the weight of your limbs upon my neck.
I'll support *you* on my shoulders. This labour won't burden me greatly.
Come what may in the fall of events, we'll share every danger.

pg 51

- 710 Safety for one will be safety for both. Let the little Iulus
Walk alongside, and my wife follow on* in our tracks at a distance.
Slaves, you must pay full attention now as I'm giving instructions.
Just as you're leaving the city, you'll find there's a mound and an ancient
Temple of Ceres* Abandoned, and, near it, a very old cypress,
715 Nursed over many long years by our fathers' attentive devotion.
This will be our one point of assembly from every direction.
You, father, take in your arms our ancestral gods and the relics.
I cannot, for I have come from a huge battle and recent bloodshed:
That would be sacrilege—till I am cleansed in a live source of running
720 Water."
 'This said, I stoop and slip over my neck and broad shoulders a tawny
Lion's skin for a cloak; then I raise up my burden. Iulus,
Still the small boy, takes my right hand and holds it with intertwined fingers,
And, since his stride's not as long, lags behind, trailing after his father.
725 Further back comes my wife. On we go through the darkest of places.
I, who, just moments ago, didn't flinch at a volley of javelins
Or at contingents of Greeks falling out from their march to attack us,
Cowered whenever a breeze blew now, so tense that the slightest
Sound made me twitch out of equal fear for my comrade and burden.
730 Now I was nearing the gates. In my mind, I could see myself past them,
Totally clear, when persistent sounds seemed to steal on our hearing
Suddenly, as of the tramping of feet. Looking out through the darkness,
Father exclaimed: "Hurry, son! Son they're getting so very much closer!
Shields glowing bright and the flash of their bronze: I can actually see them!"
735 This is when some malign power exploited my panic and plundered
What confused part of my mind I still had. While I took to the side streets,
Ran well beyond the network of roads that were known and familiar,

pg 52

- Lord, was it pitiful fate that made off with my wife? Did Creusa
Pause for a rest or stray from the path or slump in exhaustion?
740 There's no way to be sure. She was never restored to my eyesight.*
I didn't know she was gone. For I didn't look back, didn't even
Think back about her until we'd arrived at the mound and the sacred
Precinct of Ceres the Ancient. When all those assembled were counted

She was the only one lost, fooling comrades, her son, and her husband.
 745 What human being, what god did I not accuse in my madness?
 Or what crueller sight* did I see in the sack of the city?
 'Handing Ascanius, Teucrian gods, and my father Anchises
 Over to comrades, I leave them concealed in the bowl of a valley,
 Put on my glittering armour, head back on my own to the city.
 750 It's my resolve to retrace each step that we took, each occurrence,
 All through Troy, to expose my person, again, to the dangers.
 First, I go back to the walls and the dark passage under the gateway
 Through which we'd left, looking out for, and carefully tracking the footprints,
 Back through the darkness of night, with my only lantern my eyesight.
 755 Horror beleaguered my mind; even silence itself brought me terror.
 First I head back to my home, just in case, by some chance, some remote chance,
She'd returned there. The Danaäns had stormed in, controlled the whole building.
 Up it goes! Fire is consuming my house, bellowed high by the updraughts,
 Up to the roof. Flames roar to the sky in a mad dance of triumph.
 760 'I press on. I revisit the fortress and palace of Priam.*
 Now, in the emptied cloisters of Juno's Shrine for the Helpless,
 Chosen guards stand watch: they are Phoenix and ruthless Ulysses,
 Keeping their thefts clear of thieves. At this central point, all the treasures
 Stripped from the burned-out temples of Troy are collected: the holy
 765 Tables, the solid gold chalices too, all the prisoners' clothing
 Dumped in a heap. Children, and, set in long, ranked terror, their mothers,
 Stand in a circle.
 This didn't stop me from daring to hurl my cries through the ghostly
 Darkness and filling the streets with my shouts of "Creusa! Creusa!"
 770 Calling her vainly, again and again with the loud voice of anguish.

pg 53

Then my eyes saw, while I dashed in an endless search through the city's
 Buildings, a vision, my fear's worst fulfilment: the ghost of Creusa,*
 Looming before me: her image was as I remembered, but grander.
 Stunned, hair standing erect, voice choked in my throat, I stood stock-still.
 775 Uttering words to allay my concerns,* she addressed me in this way:
 "Why, sweet husband and partner, are you indulging your frantic
 Grief so intensely? For these events haven't evolved without heaven's
 Guidance. You can't take Creusa from here as companion. That isn't
 God's will. The ruler of lofty Olympus expressly forbids it.
 780 Long years of exile await; you must plough vast stretches of salt sea.
 Then you will reach the Hesperian land, where the Lydian Tiber
 Flows a straight course without waves amid farmlands fruitful and peopled.

Born for you there is a blessed state, royal power and a royal
 Partner in marriage. So staunch all tears for beloved Creusa.
 785 I'll never see the proud lands of the Myrmidons or the Dolopians,
 I won't go as a slave to the housewives of Greece. I'm of Dardan
 Blood, and by marriage, a daughter of Venus divine.
 Mighty Cybele, Mother of Gods, keeps me here on her home shores.
 Now farewell. Maintain your love for the son that we both made."
 790 When she'd said this, though I wept and so wanted to utter so many
 Words, she deserted me, fading away on the winds without substance.
 Three times I tried to encircle her neck with my arms as I stood there,
 Three times, alas, all in vain. For the image eluded my grasping
 Hands, like a slight puff of air, as a dream flutters off from a dreamer.

 795 'So it all ends, and the night's used up. I go back to my comrades.
 And, when I get there, I'm awed to discover there's been an impressive
 Influx of newcomers,* mothers and fighters, the cream of our young folk
 Massed for a journey to exile—a host of the sad and dejected
 Gathered from everywhere, ready in heart and equipment to travel
 800 Over the seas to whatever terrain I might want them to settle.
 'Venus, star of the morning,* was rising above Ida's topmost
 Ridges restoring the daylight; Danaän blockades were controlling
 Every approach to the gates. There was no hope of help whatsoever.
 Shouldering father I made for the mountains. I'd lost, and I knew it.'

NOTES

2 *Aeneas ... began thus*: Virgil builds on various traditions about Aeneas at Troy, ranging from an heroic withdrawal to an escape negotiated with the Greeks. Octavian would not have sponsored an obviously treacherous Aeneas; but the many influential Romans who accepted Octavian's rule reluctantly would have had no use for an *Aeneid* that parroted imperial propaganda. Virgil's Aeneas makes his 'own' case, in his 'own' voice. He neither confronts nor contradicts negative traditions, but assimilates them with remarkable finesse. He needs finesse on other fronts, too. Like Homer's Odysseus in Phaeacia, he is addressing an inner audience whose goodwill and support are crucial. But both heroes must avoid absorption into their hosts' worlds if they are to fulfil their own goals or obligations. Aeneas' narrative, like Odysseus' in *Odyssey* 9–12, is not just a travelogue, but a shrewd rhetorical design to secure passage out of the host's domain. In Homer, the king wants Odysseus gone; but the king's daughter, backed by the queen, wants to marry him. Odysseus manipulates their differing interests to his own advantage. Aeneas has to deal with Dido who is king, queen, and princess all in one, and thus more dangerous. He must clear his name (but not appear too threatening or desirable to her), and insist, with polite obliquity, that his destiny lies in Italy, not in North Africa.

12 *recoils from the anguish*: Aeneas shows a formidable capacity for analysing how the mind works. He characterizes himself by his tendency to avoid unhappy memories and will later show that this avoidance extends to reactions in his unconscious mind.

66 *You'll learn them all*: Aeneas sets up Sinon as a model of Greek unreliability, as a reason for scepticism about any stories of Troy a Greek (including Homer) might tell. Sinon's voice lets him answer Dido's question about the horse ('the trap' 1.753) without knowing too much 'himself'. Virgil's model may again have been Sophocles (a master of oblique speech), who wrote tragedies (now lost) named *Laocoön* and *Sinon*.

79 *See, none*: Sinon's name creates wordplay on the Latin *si non* ('if not', 'unless').

82 *Belus' descendant*: to distinguish this Belus too finely from the Phoenician Belus (see note to 1.346) is to miss Aeneas' shrewd rhetoric. Palamedes was credited with inventing a way of writing Greek in letters adapted from the Phoenician alphabet. His death is also linked to his skill in writing. When Ulysses feigned insanity to avoid conscription for the war, it was Palamedes who proved his madness false. Ulysses, in revenge, had his scribes forge a letter indicating Palamedes' intent to betray the Greeks (the subject of Euripides' lost tragedy *Palamedes*). Ulysses had gold 'planted' below Palamedes' bed and left the letter for Agamemnon to find. Palamedes was condemned and stoned to death.

100 *Calchas*: a Greek seer who helps Ulysses manipulate the ranks through their superstitions.

112 *interlocked maple*: a wood harder than the pine used for the frame.

114 *Eurypylus*: famous for going to Patras after the Trojan War and for *ending* that city's annual sacrifice of its handsomest boy and girl.

118 *the sacrifice human*: Aeneas has Sinon modify the traditional oracle demanding a human sacrifice before the Greeks' return voyage by adding 'Argive, again'. The usual victim is Priam's daughter Polyxena, killed on the grave of Achilles. Human sacrifice is treated as criminal here as in the tragic poets. Cicero calls it 'a monstrous and barbarous custom' (*Pro Fonteio* 31); Julius Caesar says much the same (*Gallic Wars* 6.16). But Octavian sacrificed humans on the anniversary of Julius Caesar's death (Suetonius, *Divus Augustus* 15), and Aeneas later takes prisoners for sacrifice (see notes to 10.520, 558). The practice was not as uncommon at Rome as is sometimes suggested (the closeness of the words for enemy and sacrificial victim, *hostis* and *hostia* respectively, build the idea into the language). Gladiatorial contests were first given at Rome as a sacrifice honouring the dead.

164 *Tydeus' unrighteous son*: Diomedes, unrighteous because he fought the gods.

176 *templed sky*: Latin *extemplo*, 'suddenly', derives from *templum*, 'temple', not just a building but a region of the sky for taking auspices (that is, omens from the flight of birds).

263 *first was Machaon*: Aeneas' list suggests an eyewitness account, especially in its adjustment of the order of their appearance.

286 *wounded*: Aeneas contends (a) that he was asleep when the Greeks left the horse; (b) that his unconscious mind had not accepted Hector's death; (c) that his unconscious had rationalized Hector's death as a long, inexplicable absence and could not account for Hector's lacerated condition, which he obviously knew about consciously but had rejected subconsciously. This is the most complex ancient account I know of suppression by the unconscious of fact known to the conscious mind.

318 *Panthus*: a Greek from Delphi abducted to Troy, father of one of Troy's wisest and best warriors, Polydamas. Priam made him priest of Apollo in compensation for his abduction. The grandson with him is, possibly, Polydamas' child Leocritus. Polydamas himself is not named in the *Aeneid*.

339–41 *Rhipeus ... Coroebus*: only Coroebus figures in other traditions (in Euripides' *Rhesus*). Virgil assigns him the role Homer gives to Othryoneus (*Iliad* 13.363 ff.).

395 *each one arming himself*: Aeneas shows Coroebus taking the lead, and does not describe his own donning of Greek armour (the verbs are in the third person). But it becomes clear that he too was in Greek armour, as the verbs revert to first person plural. It would thus be easy to confuse him with the Greeks.

396 *we mixed with Danaäns*: Aeneas has now explained why he could be represented as 'mixed in with' Danaän leaders, even as fighting on the Greek side, on the temple reliefs in Book 1.

437 *wound from Ulysses*: Ulysses' wounding of Pelias draws attention to Aeneas' failure to name any Greek warrior he fought personally.

441 *tortoise formation*: a Roman rather than Greek siege tactic: the infantry's shields were linked to form a 'roof' over their heads as the legions assaulted enemy defences.

457 *Dragging*: the tower Aeneas ascends is the one to whose pinnacle Astyanax, son of Hector and Andromache, was dragged in theatrical versions of the fall of Troy (e.g. Seneca's *Trojan Women*) and thrown to his death. Aeneas undermines this tradition by claiming he was on and destroyed that tower *before the siege ended*. Perhaps the negative tradition suggested that he witnessed Astyanax' death.

470 *Pyrrhus dances*: the *pyrrhicha*, a dance performed in armour, was allegedly named after Pyrrhus.

482 *Opening up a great window*: Aeneas now places himself at ground level *outside* the palace, as if he were with the Greeks, looking over Pyrrhus' shoulder.

506 *Priam's fate*: Aeneas re-frames Priam's death from the Trojan side, as if he were on a rooftop *inside* the palace compound. For once, the two opposing Aeneases of tradition are juxtaposed, not assimilated. But the 'Trojan' version is the one from which his narrative continues.

518 *the arms of his young days*: Priam, unlike the snake to which Pyrrhus is compared, cannot regain his youth by donning the warrior 'skin' of his youth.

543 *Hector's ... corpse*: in *Iliad* 24, Achilles pities Priam and returns Hector's body for burial.

555 *spectator at Troy's Fires*: Aeneas, a non-intervening observer, presents Priam as himself reduced by old age to the role of spectator at Troy's fall, then butchered when he tries to intervene. But when he adds that Priam's headless corpse lies on the seashore, he is adducing yet another tradition in which Priam was executed on the beach. Some see Virgil intruding upon Aeneas' narrative here with a reference to the death of Julius Caesar's

adversary, Pompey, in his own way 'Ruler of Asia'. Pompey was killed by a Macedonian (named Achilles!) on the coast of Egypt, where he fled after his defeat in 48 BC.

567 *I was the last one alive*: lines 567–88 are not in the major manuscripts. Servius says this passage was removed by Virgil's editors. Many think these lines are not genuine; but omitting them creates as many problems as it solves since it leaves a gap in the narrative: what scholars call a *lacuna*. The only similarly large *lacuna* postulated in Latin epic is in Silius 8.29–192 (which also shows Aeneas in what some would consider a 'bad light').

568 *on guard ... at Vesta's / Shrine*: the idea of killing Helen as she hides in Vesta's shrine is a clever touch, whether one accepts this passage as genuine or not. Girls selected to guard Vesta's temple at Rome had to remain virgins through thirty years of service. If they did not they were buried alive.

569 *Tyndareus' daughter*: Helen is sometimes daughter of Zeus, sometimes (especially when belittled) daughter of Tyndareus, king of Sparta.

577 *her uncle's*: reading *patruas*, not Servius' reading *patrias*: 'her father's'.

587 *Vengeance we burned for*: reading *flammae* ('flames'), not *famam* ('rumour', 'reputation') with the manuscripts.

602 *gods' inclemency*: clemency was deemed the most godlike of virtues. The description, by Venus' son and attributed to Venus, of Troy's destruction by the gods' inclemency is dubious in Stoic terms; in Epicurean terms, impious. His point is that no human is to blame for Troy's fall: not Helen, not Paris, not himself.

615–16 *Pallas ... aegis and gorgon*: Pallas is Virgil's preferred name for Minerva. She is traditionally represented with her shield, the aegis, whose central motif is Medusa's head, which turns to stone those who gaze upon it.

632–3 *the goddess / Guiding me*: Aeneas stays in the foreground of his narrative after Venus' intervention, and emphasizes the divine influences that prompt him to escape Troy.

642–3 *Troy / Fall once*: Hercules had conquered Troy earlier; see note to 8.157.

649 *Blasted me down*: Jupiter punished Anchises for his affair with Venus by maiming and disfiguring him.

671 *Buckling a sword on again*: Aeneas implies that he laid down his arms on reaching home, although he wants everyone to leave with him immediately, perhaps to establish that he is no longer wearing Greek armour. Presumably he now dons a second set of Trojan

armour. Epic warriors, regardless of rank, normally own only one. He puts armour on yet again at 2.749 to return to Troy.

676 *Taking up arms*: one cannot take up arms without 'laying down' (that is, placing) hope in their success.

691 *augural sign*: following Servius' reading *augurium*; the manuscripts have *auxilium*, 'help'.

711 *and my wife follow on*: Pausanias (10.26.1) reports a tradition dating back to the *Cypria* (an early Greek epic) that Aeneas' wife was named Eurydice. So Aeneas is probably building on the myth of Eurydice, wife of Orpheus, here and linking it with his own 'experience'. The dead Eurydice was to follow Orpheus back out of the underworld, if he did not look back, and be restored to life. Aeneas' wife will be lost because he *fails* to look back.

714 *Temple of Ceres*: in the negative tradition, this was the site arranged with the Greeks as a rendezvous for those Trojans allowed to leave.

740 *never restored to my eyesight*: but in 2.772 he tells of seeing her ghost, which, though not the same as seeing *her*, suggests her (temporary) restoration to his vision. See also next note.

746 *crueller sight*: the sight, presumably, of the whole group with Creusa alone missing.

760 *I revisit the ... palace of Priam*: since Aeneas went to the palace *before* going home for Creusa and Anchises, there was no particular reason to suspect Creusa would be there. But his frenzied search for her affords a chance to dispose of accounts that place him in Troy among the Greeks after the fall.

772–84 *the ghost of Creusa*: the conjuring of Creusa's ghost would (a) remind Dido of her husband's ghost urging her to leave Phoenicia; (b) absolve Aeneas of responsibility for Creusa's death; (c) authorize his leaving the city; and (d) tell him where he must go: to the Lydian Tiber, namely Italy (not Carthage). Aeneas indicates no recollection of Creusa's injunction to look for the Lydian Tiber as his travels begin in Book 3. If we feel like prompting him by echoing Creusa's words we are responding exactly as Aeneas' formidable rhetoric expects Dido to respond: 'You must settle and marry a new wife in Italy, not Thrace, not Crete, not ... Carthage.'

775 *to allay my concerns*: see note to 3.153.

797 *Influx of newcomers*: at the Temple of Ceres.

801 *Venus, star of the morning*: Venus is both the morning and the evening star, depending on whether she precedes sunrise or follows sunset.